Ibn Batuta is one of the greatest travel writers of all time. Originally from Tangier in Morocco, he was a near-contemporary of Marco Polo, and travelled across the known world through North Africa, the Middle East, Central Asia and India, and eventually to China. He then made his way back to Morocco before orally recording the story of an adventure that had lasted almost three decades. When he arrived in Delhi, Muhammad Tughlaq ruled from his new palace in Jahanpanah. This was a time when the erratic despot was trying to build up the prestige of his court by importing learned Muslim scholars. Ibn Batuta soon found himself a lucrative position and spent several years in the city.

He has left us a very vivid description of the Tughlaq court. He tells us that one had to pass through three gates to enter the Sultan's audience hall. There was a platform in front of the first gate where the executioners sat. When a man was sentenced to death, he would be executed outside this gate and his body would be left there for three days as a warning to others. The first gate also had a number of trumpeters and pipe-players. Whenever a notable arrived, they would blow the trumpets and loudly announce the person's name. Between the first and second gates, Ibn Batuta tells us, were platforms occupied by large numbers of palace guards.

At the second gate sat the royal ushers in gilded caps, the chief usher wielding a golden mace. Inside this gate was a large reception hall where people could sit as they awaited their turn. The visitor would then walk up to the third and final gate where scribes entered the person's name, time of arrival and other details. A nobleman who had failed to attend the court for more than three days without a valid excuse was not allowed beyond this point except by the Sultan's explicit permission. Beyond this gate was the main audience hall, a large wooden structure of 'a thousand pillars'. [20]

The Sultan sat on a raised throne supported by cushions. An attendant stood behind the king and flicked a flywhisk to chase away the flies. (Well, you cannot leave dead bodies lying around on the front porch for days and not expect flies.) In front of the Sultan would be members of the royal family, the nobility, the religious establishment, the judiciary and so on. Each person was accorded a position according to his status. We are told